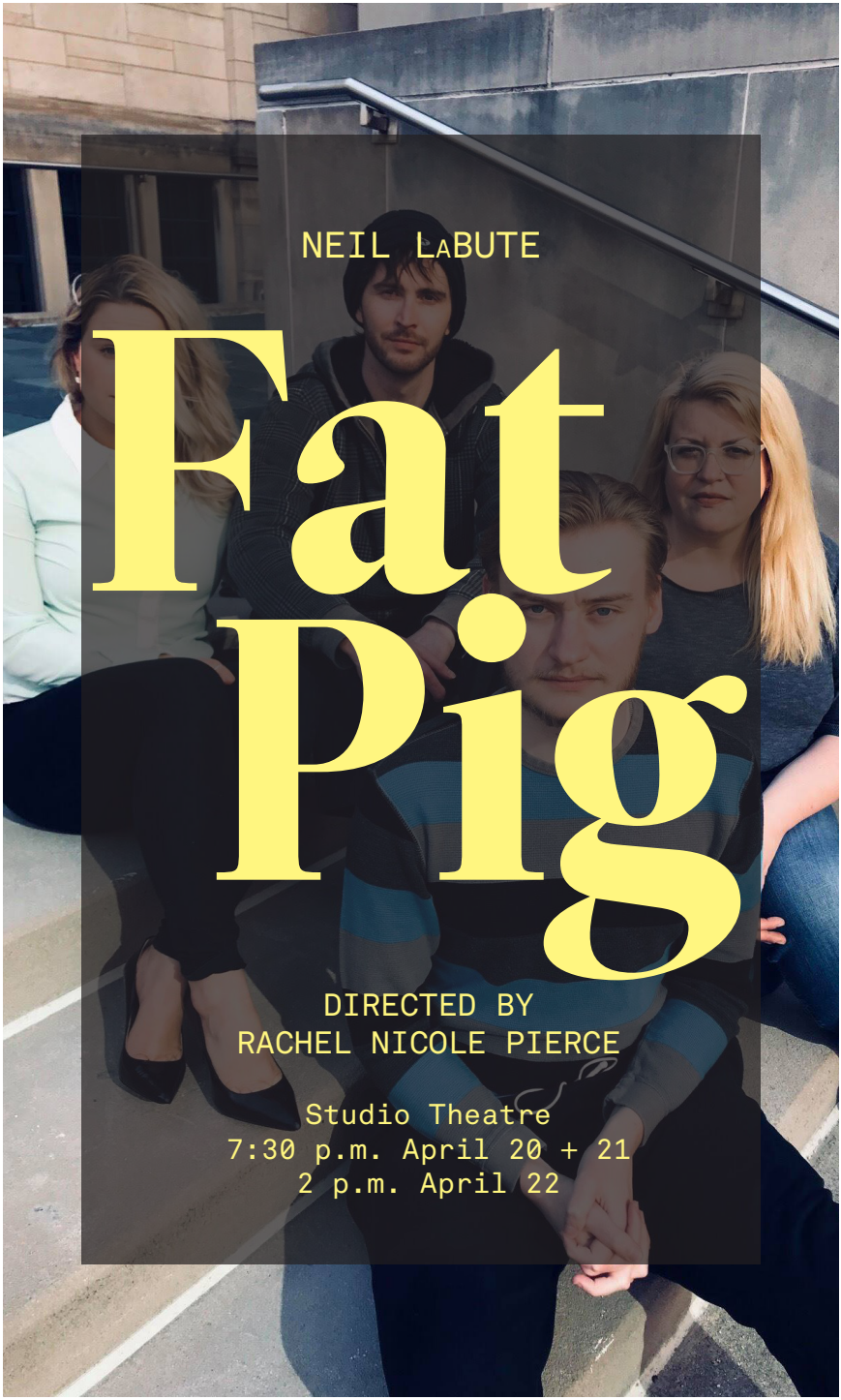

NEIL LABUTE

Fat Pig

DIRECTED BY
RACHEL NICOLE PIERCE

Studio Theatre
7:30 p.m. April 20 + 21
2 p.m. April 22

CAST

Helen	Bridget Sundin
Tom	Michael Bayler
Carter	Nicholas Jenkins
Jeannie	Ellise Chase

SETTING

A city near the Pacific Ocean

TIME

Late 1990s

CREATIVE TEAM

Lighting Designer	Tess Cunningham
Dramaturg & Sound Designer	Kathryn Reyes de la Rosa
Stage Manager	Lexi Duddleson
Assistant Director	Caitlin Noppenberger
Faculty Adviser	Dale McFadden

SPECIAL THANKS

Dan Tracy, Thomas Quintas and Susan Chase

DRAMATURGICAL NOTE

Fat Pig forms a trilogy with Neil LaBute's plays *The Shape of Things* and *reasons to be pretty*, with the conceit of exploring our obsession with physical appearance. To do so as theater, in our field where conventional beauty really does come close to currency, is a challenge that has led me to question: how does this obsession manifest in ways that aren't referring to a woman as "fat sow"?

I hear it in calling cheat days "fat days," in counting calories as conversation, and in checking nutrition facts "like a Bible scholar," as Tom jokes in *Fat Pig*. If there's a distinction between a culture that encourages healthy living and a culture that subliminally screams that to have a fat body is a fate worse than death, it's a blurry one.

In Helen's words: "The trick is getting other people to be okay with it." The fight to celebrate and to exist in a fat body is a fight against an inescapable culture that Helen and her actor Bridget face every day.

LaBute's recent fall from grace, if grace is the residency at Off-Broadway's MCC Theater he's held for years, has been cause for celebration by feminist theater makers — and a source of anxiety for our production, which started rehearsal two weeks after the news broke and whispers of #MeToo followed.

I read *Fat Pig* with some mercy. While Carter and Jeannie fulfill the requisite LaBute monstrousness, I think he casts a compassionate eye to Helen that is infrequent in the rest of his writing. I hope this is one of the last productions of his work we do.

— Kathryn Reyes de la Rosa

DIRECTORIAL NOTE

This play is one of the only works that intimately features a "othered" woman (by weight, size, and stature) onstage. Although this play is written by a man who has a track record for being more of a "Carter" than a "Tom," yet I still find valuable moments to examine in this piece. There are, of course, parts of the play that resonate with me as a female growing up around a diverse array of bodies and parts of this play that I find to be highly problematic, icky, and difficult to justify. I believe that Neil LaBute possesses a limited scope of vision when it comes to bodies, beauty, social norms...even love. This project inspires me, as a woman, to create more work that is in the same vein as this play and an increase of depth, and further - a play written by a woman+. I find it fascinating where we've come as a society....with regard to judgement, condemnation, and "fat" shaming bodies. Even more so, I contemplate how much more progress is needed to accept and embrace bodies.

As you experience this production of *Fat Pig*, I hope you find moments that make you smile, piss you off, disgust you, and leave you wanting something other than what's offered. If this play were in 2018, what would change? What does a contemporary audience need that a 1998 version of this play lacks - what still holds true...When it comes to beauty, love, and acceptance - where do you stand?

— Rachel Nicole Pierce

program design by kathryn de la rosa